

Answer this. You are catching a long-distance flight and just before take-off, you decide to download and watch *RRR*, the southern blockbuster, which is a three-hour extravaganza, on your iPad. Even if you subscribe to the best broadband service in India, currently it would take close to half an hour to do so. So, you would dump the idea, right? But imagine if you had a network that could allow you to download the full movie in less than a minute. Next, let's take your favourite sport—cricket, we guess. You think watching it on your high-definition TV on a big-size screen with surround sound is the closest you can get to viewing it live. Well, think again. You can sport a virtual reality (VR) headset and catch the action in real time from any vantage point as though you are in the stadium where the match is being played.

All this may seem too good to be true, given that call drops and connectivity issues are rampant even in our cities, not to talk of far-flung areas. However, the implementation of the fifth-generation telecom network technology or 5G is set to change all that—with at least 10 times faster data transmission than what the current 4G offers. The recently-concluded auctions of 5G spectrum or radio waves to Indian telecom operators could kick off the process of delivering the immense promise that the technology offers. In the fray were the three private service providers—Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel and Vodafone Idea. The state-owned Bharat Sanchar Nigam Ltd (BSNL), which is

THE EVOLUTION



3G *[2001]*

▸▸ 2 MBPS

GLOBAL ROAMING, EMAIL, VIDEO STREAMING



2G *[1991]*

▸▸ NA

IMPROVED SOUND QUALITY, ENCRYPTED COMMUNICATIONS, SMS MESSAGING



1G [1979]

▸▸ NA

VOICE CALLS OVER MOBILE PHONES

[Year introduced]

▸▸ Average data speed

Wireless features

Source: CENGN's global timeline of cellular phone generation; media reports